

## Vendor Training: Pre-Authorization and Orientation

**Policy:** The local agency will conduct pre-authorization and initial orientation activities at the vendors in their area as instructed by the State WIC Benefit Delivery Unit (BDU).

**Regulation:** 7 CFR 246.12

### Procedure/Additional Guidance:

Pre-authorization site visits are conducted as part of the application process for new vendors seeking WIC authorization. Once COWIC determines a vendor's application is complete and they are eligible for WIC authorization, a pre-authorization visit to the store is scheduled. This visit consists of verifying that WIC minimum stock requirements are being met, prices are posted, and WIC foods are fresh and within their expiration date. Following a successful inspection, training is provided, and the grocery store or pharmacy will become an authorized WIC vendor.

If minimum stocking requirements are not met, the vendor will have one opportunity to come into compliance with the stocking requirements. The vendor will have 20 days from the date of the pre-authorization visit to correct any findings. If it is determined that the selection criteria have not been met, the application is denied.

The local WIC agency will conduct an orientation session with at least one representative of the store within 45 days after receipt of the application. If the store is applying under a new Agreement, the LARC will complete a pre-authorization visit within 45 days of receipt of the application. However, the Colorado WIC Program may require a pre-authorization visit within 14 days to confirm the vendor's compliance with the selection criteria.

The purpose of the orientation visit is to:

- Provide training to store representative(s) on WIC training topics, including benefits and nutritional goals of COWIC, why specific foods are prescribed, and details of the Food List.
- Review WIC transaction procedures.
- Discuss Program policies and procedures and the sanctions for noncompliance.
- Identify any areas that are out of compliance with Program policies and procedures and set a mutually agreed upon plan and date for correction.
- Provide training and support to the store representative(s) through information and tools so that they can successfully conduct cashier initial preparation training on WIC policies and procedures. A physical copy of the WIC Handbook can be requested.

### Training and Documentation

Store and chain managers are responsible for training cashiers, as well as other staff involved with WIC transactions, on accepting eWIC cards so that they are comfortable and prepared to take eWIC transactions by providing initial cashier training. Section VI details WIC training. Store trainers are welcome and strongly encouraged to be in attendance at the orientation visit that is conducted by WIC staff and to use tools and materials provided by WIC in their cashier training. Internal training processes used to conduct initial cashier training should be submitted to COWIC for approval.

Training must be documented, provided to WIC, and a copy maintained in the WIC manual as required.

The Pre-Authorization Report Form, as well as additional details are available in the Vendor Handbook and through the State Office WIC Project Assistant.